DIIC Assignment 1 - Group 6

LAB 1 - Tuesday 9:30h - 12:30h

(ist1109685, ist1109366, ist1109424, ist1110570, ist1109426)

Design Context: Deaf adults - Hospital

Statement

Deaf adult patients need to communicate effectively and independently with a medical practitioner, ensuring accurate diagnosis, medical confidentiality and a safe healthcare environment.

Argument

According to the World Health Organization, over 430 million people worldwide have disabling hearing loss [1], with deaf adults facing significant disparities when accessing healthcare services [2]. In hospital environments, effective communication is critical, yet deaf adult patients routinely experience severe barriers due to the reliance on spoken language and the lack of readily available sign language interpreters or accessible non-verbal communication tools [2].

Standard communication methods, such as lip-reading, written notes or relying on family members to translate to sign language, are inadequate for complex medical terminology and prone to misunderstanding [3]. Having to share sensitive medical conditions through untrained intermediaries strips deaf patients of their autonomy and confidentiality[4].

Driven by strict time constraints and ongoing communication gaps, preventive healthcare is frequently delayed or sidelined [5]. An extreme example of these barriers involves deaf parents who, due to the absence of hospital interpreters, only learned about their son's terminal condition when the child was on the verge of dying [6]. Ensuring clear, direct, and private communication in hospital settings is vital to safeguard patient autonomy, protect personal health information, and eliminate systemic health inequities.

References

1. World Health Organization (2024). Deafness and hearing loss. Available at: https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/deafness-and-hearing-loss
2. Kuenberg, A., Fellinger, P., Fellinger, J. (2016). Health Care Access Among Deaf People. Available at: https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/26405210/
3. National Association of the Deaf (2025). Position Statement on Health Care Access for Deaf Patients. Available at: https://nad.org/knowledge-hub/position-statements/position-statement-on-health-care-access-for-deaf-patients/
4. Felix, A. (2021). Barriers faced by deaf people while accessing healthcare. Available at: https://www.edf-feph.org/blog/barriers-faced-by-deaf-people-while-accessing-healthcare/
5. McKee MM, Barnett SL, Block RC, Pearson TA (2011). Impact of Communication on Preventive Services Among Deaf American Sign Language Users. Am J Prev Med. Available at: https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/21665066/
6. CSD Public Policy: NAD-RID Code of Professional Conduct - Interview with Linda Durand (2018). Available at: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=i6LHNc7Y_v8